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Star Advantage: Employee Value Creation and Capture in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

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ABSTRACT

The integration of generative artificial intelligence (AI) into knowledge work is fundamentally reshaping employee performance and value creation in ways that challenge conventional wisdom. Rather than performance disparities being reduced through AI adoption, we argue that they may increase as star employees leverage superior domain expertise and strategic AI deployment to widen performance gaps—a phenomenon we term the "AI-specific Matthew Effect." These performance transformations coincide with dramatic shifts in value appropriation dynamics: Personal AI tools will enhance employee bargaining power by enabling portable, high-value outputs independent of organizational resources, whereas enterprise AI systems serve as novel isolating mechanisms that strengthen firm value capture. These developments necessitate a theoretical reconceptualization of strategic human capital frameworks. Accordingly, we introduce the AI-specific Matthew Effect to explain how AI may intensify performance stratification, modeling how AI reconfigures value creation and capture between employees and firms, and extending foundational human capital theories to account for human–AI complementarity. Our integrative theoretical framework offers critical guidance for navigating this transformation, helping organizations balance productivity gains with workforce equity in an uncertain era of interdependent human and artificial intelligence.

1 | Introduction

The emergence of generative artificial intelligence (AI) represents a fundamental shift in how organizations create and capture value through human capital resources (HCRs) (Budhwar et al. 2023; Gong et al. 2024; Nyberg et al. 2025; Sun et al. 2025). Indeed, AI adoption is prompting critical questions about how these technologies will reshape employee performance, the distribution of capabilities across the workforce, and ultimately, how value is created and appropriated by and from human capital (Chowdhury et al. 2023; Ren and Chowdhury 2025; Hillebrand et al. 2025; Pereira et al. 2023). Such issues are particularly salient within the knowledge economy, where production and services are based on knowledge-intensive activities (Powell and Snellman 2004). Initial studies suggest that AI adoption enhances firm-level productivity (Czarnitzki et al. 2023) and can reduce inequity in performance by enhancing capabilities for employees with less human capital (Noy and Zhang 2023). However, these findings may not fully capture the complex dynamics emerging in knowledge work contexts where human-led value creation is multidimensional, interdependent, and nuanced. Indeed, how AI tools are utilized by employees and firms may have significant implications for the distribution and amount of employee value creation and, just as important, who ultimately captures this value (i.e., the firm or the employee).

Generative AI fundamentally transforms the nature of employee value *creation* by introducing novel mechanisms through which human capital contributes to organizational outcomes. Knowledge workers are increasingly creating value by

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strategically deploying AI tools (Nafizah et al. 2024), working effectively with these systems (Choudhury et al. 2020), and critically assessing their outputs (Krakowski et al. 2023)—all while maintaining essential human qualities like morality, judgment, and social intelligence. At the same time, the dynamics of value *capture* are shifting dramatically as employees and organizations negotiate how to divide the benefits of AI-driven productivity gains (Campbell and Kryscynski 2019; Coff 1997). A mastery of "personal" AI tools (i.e., used without company oversight) provides employees with potential bargaining power that increases their productivity independent of firm resources. On the other hand, many organizations seek to create firm-specific knowledge resources by embedding AI capabilities within enterprise systems, thus allowing firms to retain and leverage greater shares of employee value creation. This tension creates a new strategic landscape where both parties must continuously recalibrate their approaches to maximize joint value creation while ensuring equitable appropriation (Chadwick 2017).

These transformations are particularly salient within the context of star employees, where some scholars believe that AI might reduce performance inequities between stars and their peers (Noy and Zhang 2023), thus providing organizations with greater leverage. We expect the opposite, however, and argue in favor of what we term an "AI-specific Matthew Effect," (Merton 1968) where performance disparities between star employees and their peers may actually intensify rather than diminish. As star employees leverage their domain expertise, learning agility, and strategic insight to extract disproportionate value from AI tools, we may see a self-reinforcing cycle of advantage that challenges the oversimplified notion of AI as a great equalizer (Choi et al. 2025; Jia et al. 2024; Krakowski et al. 2023). This phenomenon represents just one example of how the fundamental reconfiguration of employee value creation and capture mechanisms will reshape the workforce in ways that demand theoretical reconsideration.

The purpose of this paper is to examine how generative AI transforms the landscape of employee value creation and capture in knowledge work. We begin by exploring how AI redefines what constitutes performance, examining the emergence of meta-skills and hybrid capabilities that blend human judgment with AI integration. We then challenge conventional wisdom by proposing that AI may widen rather than narrow performance disparities through mechanisms that disproportionately benefit star employees, creating an "AI-specific Matthew Effect" (Merton 1968). Next, we analyze the shifting dynamics of value appropriation between employees and organizations as personal AI tools enhance employee bargaining power (Coff 1999), whereas enterprise AI systems strengthen firm-specific knowledge resources. Building on these insights, we extend foundational theories in strategic human capital literature, including the human resource (HR) architecture framework (Lepak and Snell 1999) and human capital emergence processes (Ployhart and Moliterno 2011) to accommodate the new realities of AI-augmented work. Finally, we outline implications for HR practice to maximize value creation while ensuring equitable outcomes in AI-augmented knowledge organizations.

This paper offers three interrelated contributions that collectively reshape our understanding of employee value in the age of AI. First, we introduce a novel conceptual mechanism—the "AI-specific Matthew Effect"—to explain how AI may amplify rather than reduce performance disparities in knowledge work. This mechanism highlights how status-based differences and attribution processes combine to disproportionately benefit star employees, reinforcing cumulative advantage and challenging the assumption that AI serves as an equalizing force (Haslberger et al. 2024; Merton 1968). Building on this insight, our second contribution develops a dynamic model of value appropriation that captures how AI tools shift the balance of bargaining power between employees and firms. This model distinguishes between personal AI tools, which enhance employee autonomy and mobility, and enterprise AI systems, which act as firm-level isolating mechanisms—together reshaping how value is created and captured in AI-augmented work (Coff 1999; Choudhury et al. 2020). Finally, we extend foundational theories in strategic human capital—specifically the HR architecture (Lepak and Snell 1999) and human capital emergence frameworks (Ployhart and Moliterno 2011)—to account for the new realities of AI-augmented work. This theoretical extension results in an integrative framework that connects performance disparities, capability emergence, and value appropriation, offering a cohesive structure for future research and practical guidance. Together, these contributions build a layered understanding of how AI transforms the mechanisms, dynamics, and theoretical foundations underpinning employee value in contemporary organizations (Call and Ployhart 2021).

Collectively, these contributions represent a significant reconceptualization of human capital theory that will reshape how scholars understand—and how firms manage—the complex and evolving relationship between employee capabilities and AI. Given the proliferation of AI in knowledge-intensive roles—and the knowledge economy's broad application across industries and workplaces worldwide—this transformation is especially salient for knowledge workers (Powell and Snellman 2004). As these roles continue to evolve, organizations must reconsider fundamental approaches to performance management, compensation strategy, talent development, and ethical AI governance. By developing more sophisticated theoretical understandings of how AI transforms HCRs and value creation processes, scholars can provide critically needed guidance for organizations navigating this significant transition.

2 | The New Performance Landscape

Generative AI is fundamentally altering what constitutes "performance" in knowledge work. Traditionally, performance conceptualizations and metrics have focused on individual capabilities, domain expertise, and the quality and quantity of task outputs (Motowidlo and Kell 2003). Performance has been understood primarily as behaviors contributing to goals for firm value creation (Call and Ployhart 2021), with assessment centered on core task proficiency, adaptability, and interpersonal effectiveness (Campbell and Wiernik 2015). This view of performance sees outputs as endogenous to an individual employee's knowledge, skills, abilities, and other resources (Cascio and Aguinis 2024). However, as AI tools become integrated into work processes, high performance increasingly depends on an employee's ability to effectively collaborate with AI systems—creating a hybrid

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performance landscape where human and machine capabilities intertwine in complex ways (e.g., Allen and Choudhury 2022; Boussioux et al. 2024; De Cremer and Kasparov 2021).

This shift creates what Krakowski et al. (2023) describe as a capability transformation through simultaneous substitution and complementation effects. Certain traditional skills become less valuable as AI can easily replicate them—analytical tasks like data analysis and summarization, routine content creation, and basic information processing are increasingly automated (Raisch and Krakowski 2021; Tschang and Almirall 2021). Simultaneously, complementary meta-skills associated with effective AI usage become critically important: Prompt engineering (i.e., the ability to craft AI system inputs to elicit optimal outputs), critical assessment of AI-generated content (i.e., fact checking AI and rooting out false "hallucinations"), and strategic tool selection (i.e., understanding which AI language model to use and how to program customized bots to perform automated tasks). This complementarity is particularly powerful when employees possess deep domain expertise, or the knowledge and skills accumulated through previous learning within a domain. Such expertise provides relevant outside information that can be integrated with AI outputs to effectively direct, evaluate, and refine AI responses for optimal results (Choudhury et al. 2020). The emergence of these meta-skills represents a fundamental shift in how organizations must conceptualize and measure performance.

The new performance landscape will increasingly reward those who can successfully integrate AI capabilities with domain expertise while maintaining critical human judgment about when and how to deploy these tools. This integration of human and AI proficiencies challenges traditional performance management approaches that often separate technical capabilities from judgment and creativity (Montag et al. 2012). Indeed, organizations must now develop more sophisticated frameworks for evaluating how effectively employees navigate the human–AI boundary to enhance their own performance. Doing so requires recognizing both technical mastery of AI tools, strategic wisdom to deploy them appropriately, and a firm grasp of the ethical boundaries that ensure both firms and workers are not harmed. As this transformation accelerates, performance disparities may increasingly reflect not just differences in domain expertise but also in the ability to harness AI's potential while maintaining uniquely human contributions (Yan et al. 2024).

3 | Stars, AI, and the Changing Performance Distribution

A critical question facing organizations is whether AI will equalize or exacerbate performance disparities among employees. Although controlled experiments and archival data suggest that AI can disproportionately *benefit* lower-skilled employees (Choi et al. 2025; Noy and Zhang 2023), we propose that in knowledge work contexts, this relationship may be the opposite (Jia et al. 2024). Specifically, we argue that star employees—those with relatively high performance (Aguinis and O'Boyle 2014), visibility (Groysberg et al. 2008), and social capital (Oldroyd and Morris 2012)—are uniquely positioned to leverage AI in ways that may widen rather than narrow performance gaps.

This counterintuitive outcome stems from three mechanisms. First, star employees possess superior domain knowledge that enables them to assess the quality of AI outputs across both personal and enterprise tools. Such an ability provides stars with opportunities to exploit the capabilities of AI tools for more strategic uses than their peers (Jia et al. 2024). Second, stars can achieve accelerated adoption and mastery of AI applications while maintaining relative privacy. Their existing skills and strategic outlook give them autonomy to experiment with a variety of AI applications that other employees may not have the desire or ability to investigate. Third, stars experience multiplicative effects when combining AI with domain expertise in ways that preserve their ability to capture value. These mechanisms build on Choudhury et al.'s (2020, 1385) observation that AI–human interactions are particularly complementary when an employee has "domain expertise, acquired through specialization and deliberate practice." Star employees, by definition, already possess this expertise and can therefore realize disproportionate performance gains from AI adoption. In the following sections, we outline how each of these mechanisms disproportionately benefits star employee performance relative to others, and how all three are compounded by what we term the "AI-specific Matthew effect."

3.1 | Mechanisms Amplifying Performance Disparities

3.1.1 | Domain Expertise and Strategic AI Deployment

Star employees possess deep domain knowledge that enables them to formulate more effective prompts, better evaluate AI-generated outputs, and more strategically balance the deployment of AI and human judgment (Krakowski et al. 2023). Consider a star management consultant analyzing a complex market entry strategy. Where an average consultant might use generic prompts yielding superficial analysis, the star leverages their industry expertise to craft targeted prompts that elicit nuanced insights about competitive dynamics, regulatory considerations, and potential market barriers. Additionally, the star's thorough grasp of their field allows them to recognize where AI outputs are presenting a flawed or incomplete picture and can be adjusted. By iteratively refining prompts, stars work with AI tools to reduce artificial noise and co-create genuinely valuable insights rather than accepting initial responses at face value.

Moreover, stars' deep expertise enables them to better identify when and how to leverage AI tools. Research on human–AI collaboration shows that individuals with strong domain knowledge are more effective at dividing problem-solving tasks between themselves and AI systems (Dell'Acqua et al. 2023). Stars can discern which parts of their work are best suited for AI support (e.g., data summarization, initial draft generation) and which require their uniquely human capabilities (e.g., client-specific recommendations, ethical considerations). This strategic division of cognitive labor mirrors how star employees collaborate with human colleagues across areas of complementary expertise or delegate appropriate tasks to others—allowing them to focus on activities that maximize the return on their core strengths. Just as they selectively rely on teammates for specialized input or operational support, stars can use AI systems

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to absorb routine workload, thereby preserving cognitive resources for high-impact decisions and insight generation. Thus, we expect that stars' deep domain expertise will function as a first mechanism through which they outperform non-stars who also make use of AI.

Proposition 1. *Deep domain expertise allows star employees to realize greater performance gains than non-stars from using AI in their work.*

3.1.2 | Strategic Adoption and Learning Advantages

Unlike their peers who may approach AI tools cautiously or adhere to organizational templates, stars are more likely to engage in independent experimentation with AI applications, testing boundaries and discovering unique applications before enterprise-wide adoption occurs (Gupta et al. 2024; Liu et al. 2018). This "first-mover advantage" in AI adoption allows stars to develop idiosyncratic workflows that maximize AI's value for their specific roles before standardized practices emerge (Davenport and Kirby 2016; Nafizah et al. 2024).

For example, a star financial analyst might experiment with multiple personal AI tools—training one for initial market analysis, another for visualizing complex data relationships, and a third for drafting executive summaries—to learn what each tool is capable of, where it breaks down, and how different configurations behave. Stars' competence, domain knowledge, and status position them to take exploratory risks others may avoid due to uncertainty or fear of deviating from expectations (Call et al. 2024). This capacity for early experimentation is reinforced by stars' elevated autonomy, looser oversight, and psychological entitlement (Aguinis et al. 2016; Webster et al. 2022), which allows them the discretion to selectively disclose how and when AI is used. As a result, stars can maintain an appearance of exceptional individual productivity while incorporating personal AI assistance in ways that remain opaque to colleagues and supervisors (Ding et al. 2025).

Proposition 2. *Star employees are more likely than non-stars to engage in strategic and early adoption of AI, accompanied by broad experimentation, which enables them to achieve greater performance gains.*

3.1.3 | Multiplicative Effects and Performance Amplification

Another mechanism through which star employees may disproportionately benefit from AI is their ability to seamlessly integrate such tools into well-established, self-structured workflows. Prior research infers that a key driver of stars' exceptional output is their proactive organization of work tasks and environments (Aguinis and O'Boyle 2014; Liu et al. 2018). Stars often engage in systematic knowledge management, maintain structured information repositories, and exhibit strong metacognitive skills—all of which are critical for effectively directing and integrating AI-generated outputs (Choudhury et al. 2020). Consider, for example, a star software engineer who already maintains extensive documentation and builds modular, reusable code. When this engineer adopts an AI coding assistant, they can capitalize on their disciplined development practices to generate, test, and deploy code at significantly greater rates than peers lacking such structure.

Because of these preexisting advantages, we expect stars to realize multiplicative rather than additive performance gains from AI integration. Although typical employees might experience a 20%–40% boost in productivity from AI use (consistent with findings from Noy and Zhang 2023), stars may see 2–3-fold improvements in output or quality as AI amplifies their already superior capabilities. Using the engineer example again, the emergence of advanced AI coding assistants (e.g., GitHub Copilot, GPT-based code generators; Yin et al. 2024) further strengthens this effect by allowing stars to scale their architectural thinking while offloading lower-level tasks such as boilerplate coding, syntax refinement, and test generation. These tools also respond best to clean, modular code and clear intent—conditions most frequently created by highly structured workflows already maintained by top performers. As a result, AI becomes not just a timesaver but a force multiplier (Brynjolfsson et al. 2021): It frees star employees from executional bottlenecks, accelerates iterative refinement, and enables them to deploy personalized AI toolchains that align with their strategic goals. Rather than leading to marginal gains in performance, AI will fundamentally transform a star's creative and production capacity by removing lower-level constraints that previously limited their output, allowing their strategic thinking and architectural skills to scale in unprecedented ways.

Proposition 3. *Superior systematic knowledge repositories and stronger metacognitive skills allow star employees to realize greater performance improvements than non-stars from AI implementation in their work.*

3.2 | Stars and the AI-Specific Matthew Effect

These three mechanisms driving performance stratification are reinforced by Merton's (1968, 1988) concept of cumulative advantage, often referred to as the "Matthew Effect" (after the biblical passage suggesting "the rich get richer"). In scientific communities, Merton observed that eminent scientists receive disproportionate credit for joint discoveries, creating a self-reinforcing cycle where recognition leads to additional resources, opportunities, and further recognition. We argue a similar dynamic might be emerging in AI-augmented knowledge work, but with a technological dimension we term the "AI-specific Matthew Effect."

Inherent in the Matthew Effect is the status-based attribution bias wherein an actor's pre-existing status significantly influences how others interpret and attribute the quality of their outputs (Kehoe and Bentley 2021). This interpretive lens becomes particularly consequential in AI-augmented knowledge work precisely because AI use is often covert or difficult to detect, creating ambiguity about the source of performance improvements. When outputs appear to exceed expectations, observers make causal attributions without complete information about the AI's contribution. These attributions tend to favor those with established status, such as stars, further reinforcing existing status

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hierarchies and accelerating cumulative advantage for stars while limiting it for non-stars. When stars produce exceptional work using AI assistance, observers are more likely to attribute the quality to the star's skill and creativity, viewing AI as merely an amplifier of innate talent. Conversely, when average performers produce work of similar quality with AI assistance, observers are more likely to attribute the improvement primarily to the AI rather than to the individual's capabilities.

Importantly, the "AI-specific Matthew effect" extends beyond instances of actual AI use, and is thus distinct from the aforementioned AI-driven performance stratification mechanisms. Even when no AI is involved, evaluators may misattribute exceptional work from average performers to AI assistance, simply because of their lower status levels. As a result, non-star employees face a double disadvantage: They are both less equipped to leverage AI strategically and more likely to have their contributions discounted—regardless of whether AI was used. In some cases, even the suspicion of AI involvement may be enough to undermine the perceived legitimacy of their work.

Thus, although AI-driven performance stratification and the "AI-specific Matthew effect" may function as two separate but conceptually related mechanisms, their interaction creates a compounding cycle of advantage that may further widen performance disparities over time. Stars who receive disproportionate credit for AI-augmented work gain additional resources, visibility, and opportunities for high-profile assignments—resources they can leverage to further enhance their AI usage capabilities and build their status. Meanwhile, average performers face a "discount factor" on their AI-enhanced contributions, potentially limiting their ability to translate improved output into career advancement or increased compensation. Average performers thus face a ceiling on the returns to their AI-enhanced efforts, as their contributions might be systematically undervalued.

This emerging pattern suggests that rather than functioning as a great equalizer, AI may actually accelerate the "superstar effect" observed in almost every context, ranging from entertainment to professional services (Frank and Cook 1995). Knowledge work may increasingly mirror winner-take-all markets where a small percentage of top performers capture disproportionate rewards (Rosen 1981), not solely because of superior ability, but also because of how their AI-augmented performance is interpreted. Organizations must grapple with this paradox as they develop strategies for AI adoption that balance innovation, productivity, and transparency against concerns about workforce equity and inclusion.

Proposition 4. *The "AI-specific Matthew effect" will prime evaluators to attribute stars' performance primarily to innate talent and non-star performance primarily to AI assistance, which enables stars to realize greater AI-enabled performance gains than non-stars.*

4 | Value Creation and Capture in the AI Era

To this point, our discussion has focused primarily on employee job performance as a driver of value creation in the AI era. Although this overlaps with the strategic human capital literature's view of value creation as the development of novel and appropriate tasks, services, or products perceived as valuable by users relative to their needs (Call and Ployhart 2021), Lepak et al. (2007) emphasized that there is a critical distinction between value creation (previously referred to as "performance") and value capture. Indeed, although interrelated, each process is distinct in shaping firm-level outcomes (Lepak et al. 2007). In contrast to value created by employee innovations, value capture concerns the monetary amount realized when these innovations are exchanged in the marketplace by various stakeholders. At the firm level, value is created through innovation, knowledge development, and dynamic capabilities that allow organizations to reconfigure resources to meet changing market demands (Teece et al. 1997; Teece and Linden 2017).

Although most work on value creation and capture has been at the firm level, recent theory has extended these ideas to the employee level—as value creation arguably starts with individuals (Felin et al. 2015). For example, Call and Ployhart (2021) theorized that the relationship between employee job performance and firm value capture is conditional and context-specific. Various types of employee performance (task, discretionary, and counterproductive) contribute differentially to value creation and capture. Moreover, the extent to which firms retain the value generated by employees is shaped by contextual factors such as labor market constraints that affect employee mobility and bargaining power. For instance, when employee knowledge is less visible to external markets, firms are positioned to capture more value from employee performance. The distribution of value between employees and firms also varies depending on the developmental phase of the employee's human capital (Morris et al. 2021). In early stages, organizations often capture a greater share of value due to lower employee bargaining power and visibility, whereas as employees gain experience, visibility, and market value, they are better positioned to appropriate a larger portion of the value they help create (Call et al. 2024; Ulrich and Call 2025).

This challenge of aligning value creation and capture is further complicated by the possibility of value "slippage"—a phenomenon in which a stakeholder responsible for generating value cannot fully retain or appropriate its benefits (Lepak et al. 2007). Slippage often arises in multistakeholder environments where various actors (e.g., firms, employees, clients) compete to appropriate residual value that is co-created among them. In these contexts, "isolating mechanisms" serve as barriers that prevent replication of value-creating activities which aid stakeholders in capturing value (Campbell et al. 2012; Chadwick 2017). For employees, such mechanisms may include specialized knowledge not documented by the firm, deep client relationships that would follow the employee if they left, and rare technical expertise in high demand elsewhere—all enhancing employees' ability to capture more value. Conversely, firms capture more value when work is embedded in team processes where individual contributions are difficult to separate, or when proprietary technologies and systems are required for employee productivity (Call and Ployhart 2021). These isolating mechanisms directly affect the bargaining power balance and determine whether the employee or the firm retains a greater share of the value created (Coff 1997, 1999).

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TABLE 1 | Contrasting value capture dynamics of personal and enterprise AI tools.

Dimension	Personal AI tools (employee-controlled)	Enterprise AI systems (firm-controlled)
Source of capability	Individually acquired and customized; often outside firm oversight	Developed and maintained by the firm; embedded in organizational systems
Bargaining power effects	Increases employee leverage by enabling independent value creation and reducing reliance on firm resources	Strengthens firm control by embedding knowledge in proprietary systems and lowering employee replacement costs
Portability and isolation	Outputs and workflows are portable across firms and difficult for employers to replicate	Value is co-specialized with firm data and systems, reducing employee portability
Ownership tensions	Attribution is ambiguous; outputs created with personal tools may lie outside firm governance frameworks	Raises questions about whether firm-trained models built on employee expertise create shared or firm-owned intellectual property
Privacy and autonomy	High autonomy, limited transparency; firms may be unaware of usage	Enables extensive monitoring and data capture, raising concerns about autonomy and surveillance

4.1 | New Dynamics Between Employee and Firm Value Appropriation in the AI Era

The introduction of AI tools fundamentally alters traditional dynamics of employee value creation and firm value capture, as depicted in Table 1. Moreover, AI introduces novel considerations regarding knowledge creation, workflow optimization, and bargaining power between employees and firms that ultimately condition human capital-based competitive advantage in organizations. Furthermore, the balance of power between employees and firms in value capture will only intensify as AI capabilities develop and become more widely accessible.

AI tools create new dimensions in which employees and firms must navigate the appropriation of value. The portability of AI-produced knowledge, the democratization of technical capabilities, and the potential amplification of individual contributions will necessitate reconsideration of traditional employment contracts. When individuals can leverage AI to create substantial value independent of firm resources, the traditional asymmetry in power between employee and employer in value capture negotiations is altered. Going forward, we (1) address how employees might increase bargaining power from personal AI tools; then we (2) counter with forces that might shift leverage toward firms using enterprise-level AI systems. Finally, we address important considerations of knowledge ownership, privacy, and employee autonomy—these considerations all being important factors that should shape how value creation and capture between employees and firms will pan out.

4.1.1 | Personal AI Tools Enhancing Employee Bargaining Power

Personal AI tools represent a transformative shift in traditional employee-firm bargaining dynamics by amplifying individuals' capacity to create value independent of organizational resources. Building on Coff's (1997, 1999) theory of employee bargaining power—which highlights information access, replacement costs, and exit costs as key determinants—AI tools can fundamentally alter this equation to employees' advantage. When employees can leverage AI assistants to enhance their productivity, creativity, and specialized capabilities, they essentially augment their strategic position within the firm-employee bargaining relationship.

The democratization of advanced capabilities through personal AI tools disrupts traditional knowledge hierarchies that have historically concentrated power within organizational structures. As employees incorporate AI tools into their workflows, they develop what might be termed "augmented tacit knowledge"—a personalized integration of human expertise with AI capabilities that becomes increasingly difficult for firms to institutionalize, replicate, or replace. This mirrors Coff's (1997) observation that knowledge-based assets paradoxically grant bargaining power to employees while serving as a source of competitive advantage to firms. The key distinction with AI tools is that employees can independently acquire, customize, and deploy these capabilities without relying on firm-specific resources or permissions, potentially reducing their dependency on firm knowledge repositories and creating new avenues for professional mobility across firm boundaries.

Unlike previous technological revolutions where organizations maintained predominant control over implementation and deployment, the personalized nature of AI tools creates a fundamental shift in power dynamics by potentially reducing all three barriers to employee bargaining power. First, personal AI tools can reduce information asymmetry by providing employees with broader access to knowledge previously concentrated within firm hierarchies. This expanded access allows employees to independently acquire strategic, technical, or contextual insights while reducing their reliance on managers or centralized knowledge centers to enable more autonomous decision-making. Second, AI may lower exit costs by making individual expertise more transferable across contexts. This increases employees' ability to apply their skills in new roles or organizations with less need for firm-specific adaptation. Third, employees potentially elevate the replacement costs firms would face, as the value created through the unique human–AI partnership becomes increasingly difficult to disentangle from the individual's

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contribution. This represents a novel form of "isolating mechanism" that operates at the individual rather than organizational level, enabling employees to appropriate greater portions of the value they create (Campbell and Kryscynski 2019).

Proposition 5a. *Personal AI tools serve to bolster employee bargaining power by enabling independent value creation and reducing reliance on firm resources.*

Star employees, compared to their non-star counterparts, are more likely to proactively develop and adopt personal AI tools due to their superior domain expertise, greater autonomy, and stronger motivation for performance optimization. Their deep understanding of task requirements and contextual nuances enables them to identify high-value opportunities for AI augmentation and to craft workflows that leverage AI in sophisticated, customized ways. Moreover, star employees often enjoy greater discretion at work and occupy roles with fewer constraints, which encourages exploratory behavior and individualized tool adoption. These conditions allow stars to build personalized AI workflows—ranging from customized bots to integrated automation pipelines—that are finely tuned to their professional strengths. In doing so, they create augmented tacit knowledge, or a synergistic blend of personal expertise and AI capability that is difficult for firms to replicate or absorb, giving them a distinctive edge in the human–AI value creation process.

This proactive adoption of personal AI tools substantially enhances star employees' bargaining power in the workplace. By reducing reliance on firm-provided systems and central knowledge structures, stars become less dependent on organizational resources while simultaneously increasing their visibility as unique contributors to firm performance. These personalized tools reduce information asymmetries by granting broader access to strategic knowledge, lower exit costs by making skills more transferable across firms, and raise replacement costs by embedding AI-enhanced knowledge in ways that are specific to the individual (Coff 1997, 1999). The result is a shift in the employee–firm power dynamic: Stars can credibly claim ownership over a larger share of the value they co-create with AI, and they are better positioned to negotiate compensation, autonomy, and mobility based on that enhanced value. Thus, the strategic use of personal AI tools enables stars to more effectively capture the performance gains they generate, reinforcing their advantage in the age of AI-augmented work.

Proposition 5b. *Stars, compared to non-stars, are more likely to proactively develop and adopt personal AI tools, which enhances their bargaining power and enables them to capture a greater share of the value created through AI-enabled performance gains.*

4.1.2 | Enterprise AI Systems as Isolating Mechanisms

Enterprise AI systems represent a strategic counterweight to the employee bargaining power enhanced by personal AI tools, potentially strengthening firms' position in value appropriation. Drawing on resource-based theory (Penrose 1959), these enterprise AI systems function as firm-specific knowledge assets that encode and embody organizational routines, collective intelligence, and proprietary data in ways that create isolating mechanisms for the firm (Barney 1991; Reed and DeFillippi 1990). As Coff (1999) argues, when knowledge resources are embedded in firm processes rather than residing solely with individual employees, firms can better appropriate the value created. Enterprise AI systems do this by encoding tacit firm knowledge into systems that remain with the firm even as individual employees depart.

These enterprise systems can enhance value capture from employee output through several mechanisms that enhance firm bargaining power. By capturing and operationalizing the specialized knowledge of multiple employees, they reduce dependency on individual talent and lower replacement costs associated with knowledgeable employees. Furthermore, enterprise AI systems increase a firm's dynamic capabilities (Teece et al. 1997) by accelerating firms' ability to sense opportunities, reconfigure resources, and respond to market changes through scaled computational intelligence that enhances firm decision-making. Such capabilities can provide the firm with a greater ability to generate and potentially capture value over time, as the causal ambiguity and social complexity associated with these systems make them difficult for competitors to imitate in dynamic environments (Sirmon et al. 2007).

Perhaps most importantly, enterprise AI systems create scalable learning advantages that individual AI tools cannot match. Organizations with access to larger datasets and more diverse use cases can develop AI systems that learn faster and create connections across previously siloed knowledge domains (Zack 1999). This usage of enterprise AI that integrates with firm-specific processes and teams creates co-specialized assets (Teece et al. 1997)—resources that are more valuable when deployed together within a specific firm context than they would be elsewhere, leading to firm value capture (Lippman and Rumelt 2003; Teece 1986; Tripsas 1997). These co-specialized assets increase the firms' bargaining power by raising the exit costs for employees who might otherwise leverage personal AI tools to capture more value, as their skills become relatively less valuable outside the enterprise AI ecosystem (Klein et al. 1978).

Proposition 6a. *Enterprise AI systems serve to increase firm bargaining power by embedding knowledge in proprietary systems and lowering the cost of employee replacement.*

Unlike star employees who often possess the autonomy, technical fluency, and strategic foresight to adopt and customize personal AI tools, non-star employees are more likely to rely on enterprise AI systems provided and managed by the organization. This reliance is not merely a matter of preference but often stems from structural constraints—non-stars typically have less discretion, fewer resources, and limited access to experimental opportunities that enable independent tool development. As a result, they integrate their work into firm-controlled AI infrastructures that embed organizational routines, workflows, and data. Although this integration enhances efficiency and consistency, it also reduces the replaceability, visibility, and attribution of individual contributions. The AI-generated outputs produced within enterprise systems are often co-created with embedded firm logic, making it harder to distinguish an employee's unique input from that of the system as a whole.

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This reliance on enterprise AI systems ultimately limits non-star employees' bargaining power and diminishes their ability to capture the value generated from their AI-enabled performance. Because the knowledge they use and produce is deeply embedded within the firm's technological infrastructure, it becomes less portable and less clearly attributable to them as individuals. Exit costs remain high, replacement costs are lowered, and the firm's control over value appropriation is strengthened—factors that align with Coff's (1999) theory of firm-level isolating mechanisms. Unlike personal AI tools that empower individuals to create and own unique workflows, enterprise systems embed the employee into a broader organizational apparatus. This dynamic positions non-stars as contributors to firm-level capabilities rather than as autonomous value creators, reducing their leverage in negotiating rewards or recognition for performance improvements. Consequently, non-stars are less able to convert AI-enabled performance gains into compensation or career advancement, further reinforcing performance-based inequality in the AI-augmented workplace.

Proposition 6b. *Non-stars, compared to stars, are more likely to rely on enterprise AI systems rather than personal AI tools, which reduces their bargaining power and leads them to capture a smaller share of the value created through AI-enabled performance gains.*

4.2 | Strategic Tension in Knowledge Ownership, Deployment, and Privacy

4.2.1 | Knowledge Ownership in AI-Enabled Knowledge Creation

The emergence of AI tools introduces unprecedented challenges to traditional frameworks of intellectual property and knowledge ownership, creating strategic tensions that significantly influence value appropriation dynamics (also depicted in Table 1). As noted, value creation and value capture are distinct processes that can be separated across different stakeholders (Lepak et al. 2007), and AI accelerates this potential separation by blurring traditional boundaries of knowledge creation and ownership. The introduction of AI as a third actor in the knowledge production process—alongside individuals and organizations—creates what can be termed a "three-body problem" in intellectual property rights that traditional employment contracts were not designed to address (Lobel 2014). This is particularly evident when employee-generated expertise is used to train enterprise-deployed AI systems, raising complex questions about whether the resulting capabilities belong to the employee, the employer, or constitute a novel form of co-created property. Interestingly, enterprise-level AI contracts are now articulating whether or not the AI is allowed to "learn" from firms' data. Because AI companies' language models are trained by their customers' data (and this data is extremely valuable for the AI company), they charge more for the language model to be "firewalled" off. This illustrates the inherent value of the knowledge assets that are gleaned from users.

These evolving dynamics extend what Coff (1999) identified as the information-based sources of bargaining power, as outputs become increasingly collaborative between humans and AI, making value attribution substantially more complex. Traditional compensation systems based on individual contributions become problematic when AI systems trained on collective firm knowledge augment individual performance in ways that cannot be easily disaggregated (Marler 2024). This tension echoes what scholars have described as the knowledge integration problem (Grant 1996) where organizations must balance individual expertise and collective knowledge resources, but now with the added complexity of AI systems that continuously learn from both sources. These conditions create a form of causal ambiguity that may actually undermine both parties' ability to claim definitive ownership of the resulting value (Call and Ployhart 2021).

Organizations will likely need to develop new governance frameworks that specify how employee knowledge enhanced by AI is shared, owned, and compensated—frameworks that balance individual incentives with firm objectives. These frameworks should attempt to establish the value appropriability regime (Teece 1986), or the environmental factors that determine who profits from innovation, by establishing more explicit claims on AI-generated value. Such frameworks will influence both how value is created, by shaping knowledge-sharing incentives, and how it is captured, by establishing property rights over AI-enhanced outputs (Anton and Yao 1994). Organizations that successfully navigate these tensions may develop knowledge protection capabilities (Liebeskind 1996) that balance openness for innovation with sufficient protection to ensure sustainable value capture, adapting traditional notions of intellectual property for an era where knowledge creation involves human–AI partnerships within firm boundaries.

4.2.2 | Privacy, Autonomy, and Creativity Considerations in AI-Enabled Value Creation/Capture

The integration of AI tools in workplace contexts introduces novel privacy considerations that significantly impact value capture dynamics. As organizations deploy AI systems capable of monitoring, recording, and analyzing employee activities at unprecedented scale and granularity, new tensions emerge between organizational control and employee privacy rights (Ajunwa et al. 2017). These surveillance capabilities fundamentally alter bargaining power relationships, potentially shifting advantage toward firms through information asymmetry while simultaneously creating what is termed a "transparency paradox" (Bernstein 2012, 2017) whereby excessive monitoring can undermine the psychological safety essential for innovation and knowledge creation. Moreover, as employees' behavioral and process data become a valuable training resource for organizational AI systems, traditional compensation models increasingly fail to account for this newly emergent form of value contribution, creating what Zuboff (2023) describes as "surveillance capitalism" dynamics operating within employment relationships. Indeed, her sobering and prophetic observations from decades ago (Zuboff 1988) may emerge in unprecedented ways in the organizational setting, where AI could represent a digital "Panopticon." As work becomes increasingly mediated by technology, every action, interaction, and decision can be captured, analyzed, and potentially used for control—eroding traditional boundaries of employee privacy (Zuboff 2019).

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Autonomy considerations in AI-augmented work environments present critical implications for value creation and capture. Research demonstrates that employee perception of autonomy significantly impacts both intrinsic motivation and creative output (Ryan and Deci 2000). When organizations implement AI systems without meaningful employee input regarding their design and deployment, they risk undermining this crucial motivational driver. Strategic human capital scholars have identified employee psychological utility as a key moderator in the relationship between performance and value capture (Call and Ployhart 2021), suggesting that diminished autonomy may reduce both value creation and employee bargaining power. Conversely, organizations that adopt participatory AI governance models may enhance an "enabling" type of formalization, where "procedures provide users with visibility into the processes they regulate by explicating their key components and by codifying best-practice routines" (Adler and Borys 1996, 72). This type of transparency should increase both collective value creation and employee willingness to contribute to organizational goals rather than seeking to maximize individual value capture.

At last, the introduction of AI tools fundamentally transforms creative processes within organizations, directly affecting how value is created and attributed. Lepak et al. (2007) identified novelty and appropriateness as the two critical determinants of value creation—particularly in how value is assessed (i.e., when actors perceive more novelty and appropriateness, valuations are higher)—both of which are significantly altered in human–AI collaboration contexts. Although AI systems can enhance certain aspects of creative work through computational support, they simultaneously risk standardizing outputs and diminishing the perceived uniqueness of human contributions (Brynjolfsson and McAfee 2014). This transformation raises profound questions about the proper attribution of creative contributions in hybrid human–AI outputs, challenging traditional models of value assessment and compensation. Firms' efforts to protect valuable intellectual assets are complicated by the increasingly fluid boundary between human and AI-generated insights, potentially weakening both individual and organizational claims to created value.

In sum, organizations must develop sophisticated governance frameworks that balance value capture objectives with ethical considerations regarding privacy, autonomy, and creativity to create sustainable knowledge ecosystems. Privacy approaches should be contextually adapted to different workplace scenarios rather than applied uniformly across all organizational settings (Nissenbaum 2009). The optimal level of privacy often depends on the nature of work being performed, organizational culture, and industry norms. Research indicates that maintaining appropriate levels of employee agency while leveraging AI capabilities helps to preserve both the ethical dimension of work and organizational performance outcomes (Frey and Osborne 2017). Understanding the various manifestations of creativity in different domains enables organizations to develop more nuanced approaches to assessing and rewarding different forms of contribution in AI-augmented environments (Boden 2004). By developing contextually sensitive approaches to these considerations, organizations can maintain employee trust and motivation while effectively capturing value from emerging AI technologies.

4.2.3 | Practical Implication

Sustainable AI adoption will require organizations, individuals, and governments to collaboratively develop contextual governance approaches that capture AI's value while preserving privacy, creativity, agency, and human dignity.

5 | Theoretical Extensions to Strategic Human Capital Literature

The preceding sections have illustrated how generative AI transforms both the mechanisms through which value is created and the dynamics by which it is captured in knowledge-intensive work. Although these insights have immediate practical implications, they also speak directly to the core theoretical concerns of the strategic human capital literature, which has long focused on understanding how firms generate and appropriate value from human capital. Foundational frameworks—such as the human capital architecture (Lepak and Snell 1999) and human capital emergence (Ployhart and Moliterno 2011)—were developed to explain variation in value creation and capture across different types of human capital and organizational contexts. As such, they are not only relevant but essential to reexamine in light of the technological shifts introduced by AI.

However, these frameworks were proposed in a context where the primary locus of capability resided within individuals or firm-specific routines. However, the integration of AI into everyday work introduces a novel category of value-generating agents and collaborative dynamics that these frameworks were not originally developed to accommodate. As AI systems begin to function as embedded partners in knowledge production, and as human–AI complementarity becomes a driver of competitive advantage, existing theories must evolve to incorporate these technological actors and the new forms of relational, procedural, and computational capital they produce. In the following sections, we revisit key components of strategic human capital research to explore how they can be extended to account for the complexities that AI adoption brings to the workplace.

5.1 | Rethinking Lepak and Snell's HR Architecture for the AI Age

Lepak and Snell's (1999) HR architecture framework provides a foundational typology for understanding how organizations manage employees with different types of human capital. Grounded in the resource-based view (RBV), the model classifies employees based on two dimensions of their human capital: strategic value—the extent to which it contributes to competitive advantage—and uniqueness—the degree to which it is rare, inimitable, and not easily transferable across firms. This yields four distinct categories of employees: core knowledge employees (high value, high uniqueness), job-based employees (high value, low uniqueness), contract workers (low value, low uniqueness), and alliance partners (low value, high uniqueness). The framework then proposes differentiated HR configurations for each category,

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aligning employment modes with the strategic importance of the human capital involved.

However, the framework's original logic assumes that value and uniqueness are relatively stable indicators of how employees should be managed, derived primarily from two dimensions of RBV: value and rarity—that is, from the firm's standpoint of resource control and competitive advantage. This focus overlooks other critical dimensions that shape the deployment and management of human capital, particularly in the context of technological change. As generative AI becomes increasingly embedded in work processes, substitutability and complementarity with AI emerge as additional characteristics that may shape how human capital should be valued and managed—even when value and uniqueness remain high.

For example, certain human skills may remain both valuable and relatively rare, yet become highly substitutable by AI. A case in point is Duolingo, which adopted an AI-first strategy and was able to develop approximately 150 new language courses using generative AI (Duolingo 2025). The underlying human capabilities involved in course creation—such as linguistic expertise, instructional design, and cultural localization—remain unquestionably valuable and difficult to acquire. However, the ability of AI systems to replicate these outputs at scale has diminished the need to manage employees with these skills under traditional "core knowledge" models. In such contexts, value and uniqueness alone may no longer justify high-commitment HR strategies if those same contributions can now be efficiently automated. Conversely, employees whose capabilities are complementary to AI—such as those who interpret AI-generated outputs, know how to effectively use AI to perform tasks like course creation, exercise moral and strategic judgment, or build trust-based relationships—may retain or even enhance their strategic relevance. These dynamics suggest that organizations must extend the traditional value and uniqueness framework to incorporate dimensions such as AI substitutability and complementarity, which more accurately reflect how human capital contributes to value creation in the age of intelligent systems.

In addition, it may no longer be sufficient to apply the HR architecture model at the job level. AI technologies often automate or augment specific tasks rather than entire job roles (Autor et al. 2024; Brynjolfsson and Mitchell 2017), meaning that a given job may consist of both automatable and non-automatable components. Therefore, applying the framework at the task or skill level becomes more analytically useful. Organizations can increasingly assess which tasks are both strategically valuable and dependent on rare, non-substitutable human skills, and then determine how to accumulate, deploy, and reward those skills—regardless of job position. This shift enables more granular and adaptive talent management, especially in knowledge work contexts where AI reshapes job content without necessarily eliminating entire roles. A skill- or task-based lens also opens the door for reconfiguring HR systems around capability portfolios (Fuller et al. 2022; Rachmad 2025), where human capital investments are aligned with the specific skill domains that resist automation and drive hybrid value creation.

Moreover, while Lepak and Snell (1999) explicitly acknowledged that employees may move across categories over time, the integration of AI adds greater complexity and acceleration to such transitions. AI tools may quickly shift the locus of value from human-only to human-machine collaboration, leading to faster reclassification of roles. For instance, a job-based employee who learns to orchestrate AI workflows may rapidly move into a core knowledge category, whereas a previously core knowledge employee may lose that status if their unique expertise becomes automatable. A recent example is Microsoft's multiple waves of layoffs in 2025, including the termination of thousands of software engineering and product management roles—traditionally considered high-skill, core knowledge positions. These layoffs occurred amid Microsoft's heavy investment in AI infrastructure and its growing reliance on AI code-generation tools (Reuters 2025). This shift has raised concerns that AI automation is eroding the strategic distinctiveness of certain knowledge roles, effectively reclassifying them as less critical. The speed, scale, and opacity of AI transformation thus amplify the challenge of managing dynamic human capital configurations, requiring continuous reassessment and strategic realignment of HR systems.

In sum, although Lepak and Snell's (1999) HR architecture remains a foundational framework for understanding workforce differentiation, it requires theoretical refinement to remain applicable in the context of AI-augmented work. Extending the framework from the job level to the task or skill level may offer a more precise lens for evaluating how human capital contributes to value creation in an era where AI systems selectively automate components of work rather than entire roles. This shift enables organizations to more effectively identify, develop, and reward the non-substitutable human skills that drive hybrid value creation alongside AI. Reframing the HR architecture in light of these dynamics thus requires integrating a more nuanced understanding of AI substitutability, complementarity, and knowledge appropriation. Such a reconceptualization is essential for advancing strategic human capital research in an era where human and machine capabilities are increasingly co-constitutive of organizational value.

5.2 | Transforming Human Capital Resource Emergence Processes

Ployhart and Moliterno's (2011) multilevel model of HCR emergence provides a foundational framework for understanding how individual-level knowledge, skills, abilities, and other characteristics (KSAOs) aggregate to become unit-level strategic resources capable of influencing key organizational outcomes. Their model, and the extended elaboration by others (e.g., Eckardt and Jiang 2019; Ray et al. 2023; Ployhart et al. 2014), marked a turning point in strategic human capital research by shifting attention from individual human capital stocks to the emergent properties of collective human capital. According to this perspective, individual KSAOs become strategic only when they emerge to the collective level through processes that enable them to influence important unit-level objectives such as performance, adaptability, and innovation.

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HCR emergence can be characterized by two mechanisms—transformation and amplification—through which individual human capital can develop into unit-level strategic resources. Transformation refers to the developmental process by which individual KSAOs are altered, enriched, or integrated through interactions among unit members and with the external environment. Transformation includes mechanisms such as knowledge transfer, shared learning, colleague-specific understanding, transactive memory, and the formation of shared mental models. Through these processes, individual KSAOs evolve into collective, interdependent capabilities that enhance unit functioning. Amplification, in contrast, involves enhancing the value and performance potential of existing KSAOs through contextual features that generate complementarities. Rather than changing the nature of individual KSAOs, amplification increases the returns derived from them by leveraging motivational and cognitive mechanisms—such as increased effort, focus, and collaboration—that enable units to perform at a level greater than the sum of individual contributions. These emergence processes are supported by behavioral (e.g., coordination, communication, regulatory routines), cognitive (e.g., shared memory, learning systems, unit-level climate), and affective (e.g., cohesion, trust, emotional alignment) states, particularly under conditions of high task complexity, which necessitate greater interdependence and shared adaptation. Together, transformation and amplification explain how individual capabilities are shaped by social and structural processes to form collective HCRs that are strategically valuable and difficult to replicate.

However, the increasing adoption of generative AI in organizations presents a fundamental shift in the context within which these emergence processes unfold. Generative AI tools have the potential to alter the conditions, speed, and pathways through which human capital emerges at the collective level, necessitating a reexamination of Ployhart and Moliterno's original framework. First, generative AI may reshape the role of task complexity as a precondition for emergence. Traditionally, task complexity necessitated greater coordination, mutual monitoring, and shared understanding among individuals (Campbell 1988; Hærem et al. 2015). Yet, with AI systems capable of handling complex analytical tasks, synthesizing large volumes of information, and automating procedural coordination, the human burden of complexity may be redistributed or even reduced (Boussioux et al. 2024; Doshi et al. 2025). This could lower the threshold for emergence by simplifying some enabling conditions, or alternatively, increase the threshold for uniquely human contribution, as AI systems absorb routine complexity. In both cases, the conditions that necessitate emergence—and the nature of what emerges—may be shifting.

Second, generative AI may significantly influence the behavioral, cognitive, and affective emergence-enabling states originally identified by Ployhart and Moliterno (2011). On the behavioral side, AI can facilitate coordination and communication by offering real-time suggestions, automating routine exchanges, providing translation, and integrating workflows. On the cognitive side, AI-enhanced knowledge platforms can augment shared memory and learning while also introducing new shared artifacts (e.g., AI-generated outputs or co-edited documents) that become embedded in team routines. On the affective side, the picture is more complex: Although AI may depersonalize interpersonal dynamics by reducing the frequency and depth of human–human interactions, it can also mediate emotional tone, de-escalate conflict through scripted dialogue, and reinforce cohesion when used to complement—rather than

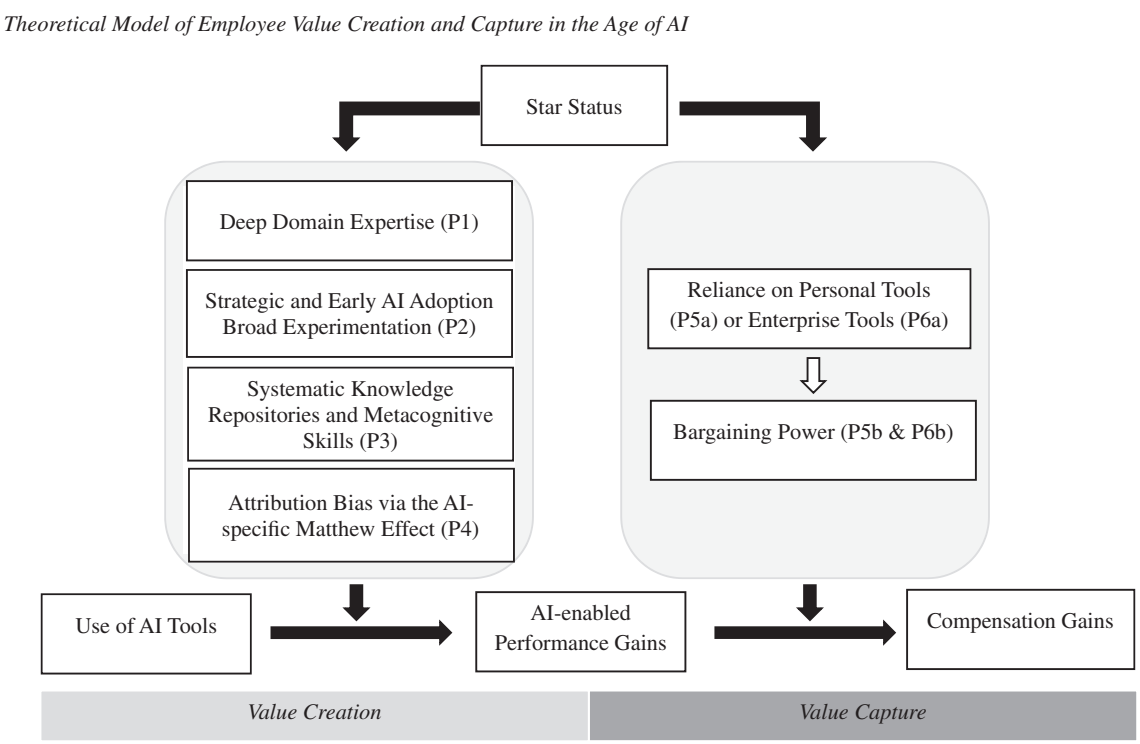

FIGURE 1 | Theoretical model of employee value creation and capture in the age of AI.

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substitute—human connection (Glikson and Woolley 2020; Seeber et al. 2020) (Figure 1).

However, the integration of AI also poses a potential disruption to the traditional emergence-enabling states. Ployhart and Moliterno's framework rests on the assumption that human capital emergence is driven primarily by social interaction and collaboration among human agents. Yet as AI increasingly mediates or replaces elements of these interactions, the frequency, richness, and developmental potential of human–human collaboration may decline (Cascio and Montealegre 2016). For example, when employees rely on AI tools for task coordination, information retrieval, or problem-solving, opportunities for peer-based learning, mutual adjustment, and the development of shared mental models may be diminished. In this sense, AI not only reconfigures the emergence-enabling states—it may also displace some of the very conditions under which collective human capital traditionally emerges. This shift calls for a reevaluation of how behavioral, cognitive, and affective processes function when human capital emergence increasingly involves human–AI rather than human–human co-creation.

Third, generative AI may introduce new forms of transformation and amplification that reshape the pathways through which individual KSAOs emerge into collective HCRs. For example, when a high-performing employee integrates personal AI workflows into their tasks, it may not fundamentally alter the content of their KSAOs, but the surrounding AI-enabled context can amplify the value derived from those KSAOs by increasing their productivity, focus, and cognitive efficiency—reflecting a form of AI-supported complementarity (Jia et al. 2024; Sun et al. 2025). At the same time, when multiple team members engage with a shared generative AI system—such as jointly refining prompts, co-editing AI-generated documents, or interpreting system-generated insights—the resulting collaboration may facilitate emergence, as individuals learn from each other and from the AI, co-construct shared mental models, and integrate task-relevant knowledge (Dell'Acqua et al. 2025). In this sense, generative AI can serve as both a cognitive catalyst for learning and convergence and a performance amplifier, simultaneously supporting the emergence of collective human capital through enriched KSAO development and enhanced synergy. These dynamics suggest that AI functions not merely as a tool for automation, but as an active agent shaping how human capital is transformed and leveraged at the unit level.

Taken together, these observations suggest that although Ployhart and Moliterno's (2011) model remains a foundational theoretical touchstone, it can be meaningfully extended to account for the novel dynamics introduced by generative AI. Specifically, the use of AI alters the enabling conditions for emergence, reshapes the mechanisms of behavioral, cognitive, and affective emergence, and introduces hybrid pathways of transformation and amplification mediated by human–AI interaction. Future research should thus revisit strategic HCR emergence with an eye toward these evolving technological capabilities, as organizations increasingly rely on human–AI teams to create and capture value in complex, adaptive environments.

5.2.1 | Theoretical Implication

Foundational strategic human capital frameworks require theoretical refinement to incorporate task-level substitutability dynamics and AI-mediated emergence processes, shifting focus from human-only interactions to hybrid human–AI value creation mechanisms.

6 | Toward a New Theoretical Framework for Understanding AI–Human Complementarity

The preceding sections have explored how generative AI reshapes foundational theories of strategic human capital by extending Lepak and Snell's (1999) HR architecture and reconfiguring Ployhart and Moliterno's (2011) model of HCR emergence. Building on our earlier discussion of how AI transforms value creation and appropriation dynamics, as articulated in Coff's (1997, 1999) work, we argue that each of these perspectives illuminates a distinct yet complementary facet of the human capital value chain—from identifying, nurturing, and aggregating human capital to capturing and protecting its strategic contributions. However, as AI becomes increasingly embedded in the fabric of knowledge work, there is a pressing need for an integrative theoretical framework that systematically accounts for AI's role across all stages of this value chain. In what follows, we propose such a framework and outline a future research agenda that reconceptualizes strategic human capital through the lens of AI–human complementarity.

We propose a multilevel, integrative framework for understanding AI–human complementarity that unites three critical dimensions of strategic human capital: configuration, emergence, and appropriation (see Figure 2). The configuration layer, grounded in Lepak and Snell's (1999) HR architecture, focuses on the classification and deployment of human capital. In the AI context, we extend this layer by introducing a new axis—AI complementarity—alongside value and uniqueness. This enables organizations to identify not only which skills are rare and valuable but also which ones are augmented versus automated by AI. For instance, interpersonal sense-making or ethical reasoning may remain non-substitutable yet highly augmentable when paired with generative AI, whereas skills like data categorization may retain value but become increasingly automatable. This expanded tri-dimensional lens provides a more nuanced basis for segmenting talent and tailoring HR systems to match emerging technological realities.

The emergence layer, rooted in Ployhart and Moliterno's (2011) framework, highlights how individual-level KSAOs transform and amplify into unit-level strategic resources. Generative AI complicates and enriches this process by serving as both a cognitive partner and an interactional mediator. For example, AI tools can facilitate real-time feedback loops, scaffold team learning through shared digital interfaces, and reduce transaction costs of collaboration—thereby altering the traditional behavioral, cognitive, and affective enabling states. In this expanded framework, emergence is no longer solely a function of human–human interaction but also of human–AI–human triadic processes, where AI serves as a catalyst for synchronizing attention, refining shared mental models, and enhancing group

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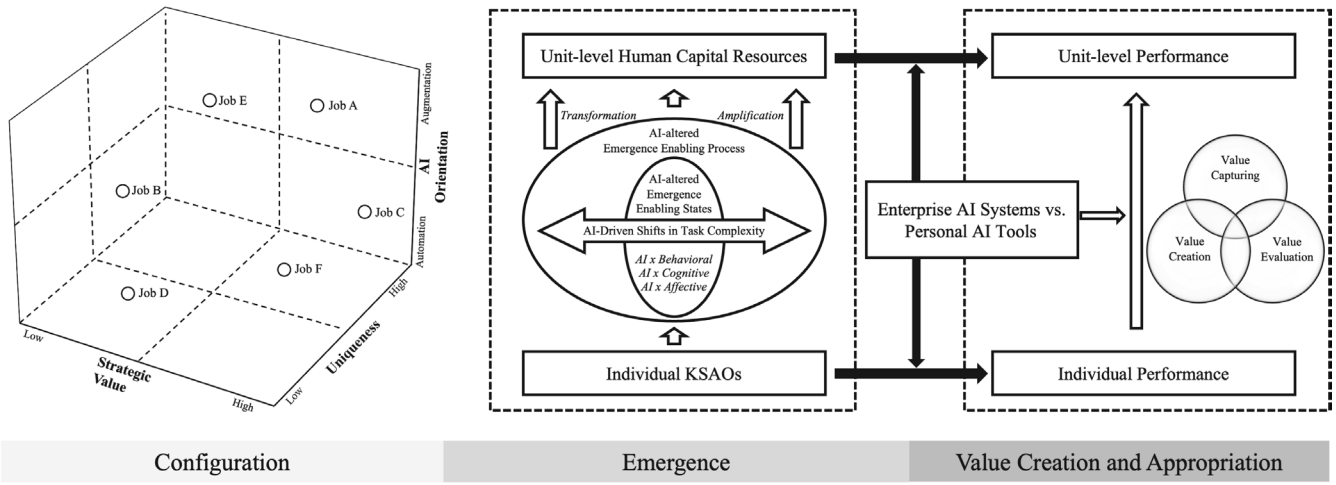

FIGURE 2 | AI–human complementarity framework.

performance. Accordingly, future research should explore how collective capabilities evolve in sociotechnical systems that blend human expertise with algorithmic scaffolding.

The final dimension of our integrative framework centers on value appropriation, drawing on Coff's (1997, 1999; Campbell et al. 2012) seminal work on the micro-political dynamics of rent distribution via human capital. Although Coff highlighted how firms use isolating mechanisms—such as social capital, causal ambiguity, and firm-specific investments—to retain control over value created by human assets, the introduction of generative AI complicates these dynamics. On one hand, personal AI tools may enhance individual bargaining power by enabling employees to produce portable, high-value outputs independently of firm resources, thus weakening traditional isolating mechanisms. Conversely, enterprise AI systems offer organizations new means of codifying, scaling, and internalizing employee contributions through firm-specific data, routines, and usage patterns—effectively functioning as novel isolating mechanisms in the AI age. In addition, the opacity of human–AI collaboration complicates attribution in performance evaluation: Star employees may disproportionately benefit from status-biased recognition, whereby AI-augmented outputs are attributed to innate talent, amplifying disparities through what we term the AI-specific Matthew Effect. Meanwhile, average performers may struggle to claim credit for AI-assisted work, particularly in systems that lack clear governance over attribution and data transparency. These shifts underscore that value appropriation in the era of AI is no longer a function of structural positioning alone, but a fluid contest shaped by access to tools, visibility of contributions, and evolving rules of ownership and recognition. As such, future research must address how organizations can develop equitable appropriation regimes that balance individual autonomy with collective value creation in AI-augmented work systems.

Taken together, these three perspectives offer ground for future research (see Table 2) on how generative AI is reshaping strategic human capital. Scholars can extend traditional frameworks by examining how AI complementarity interacts with value and uniqueness in talent classification, how AI tools influence the transformation and amplification processes through which individual KSAOs become collective assets, and how AI alters value capture. This line of inquiry encourages the field to treat AI not merely as a technological disruption, but as a co-evolving partner in the creation and distribution of human capital value.

These three theoretical perspectives—HR configuration, human capital emergence, and value appropriation—also connect back to our earlier discussion of why and how star and non-star employees experience the effects of generative AI differently. At the configuration level, stars are more likely to occupy roles that remain high in strategic value and uniqueness while also being highly AI-augmentable, enabling them to extend their advantage by developing personalized workflows and acquiring complementary skills. At the emergence level, stars often lead in shaping how human–AI interactions unfold, acting as early adopters who set behavioral and cognitive patterns that amplify their individual KSAOs into collective outcomes. Finally, at the appropriation level, stars benefit not only from more effective personal AI tool usage but also from attribution dynamics that favor their visibility and perceived contribution, allowing them to capture a disproportionate share of the value they help create. In contrast, non-star employees are more likely to be placed in roles that are more automatable, less visible in collaborative value production, and more tightly embedded in firm-controlled AI systems—limiting both their opportunity for emergence and their capacity to claim value. This multilevel framework thus reveals how AI can amplify existing differentiation in strategic human capital systems, and it underscores the importance of understanding employee–AI dynamics across classification, development, and reward processes.

7 | Implications for Practices

Although the preceding sections offer a theoretical reconceptualization of strategic human capital in the age of generative AI, these insights also carry significant implications for practitioners seeking to responsibly integrate AI into HR management. First, organizations should begin by revisiting how jobs are defined, analyzed, and managed. Traditional job-based models often obscure the fact that some tasks within a role are highly automatable, whereas others are uniquely human and less substitutable. Firms should undertake a systematic task

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TABLE 2 | Future research agenda on AI–human complementarity in strategic human capital.

Theoretical lens	Core insight	Illustrative research questions	Theoretical contribution
HR architecture (Lepak and Snell 1999)	AI complementarity reshapes how human capital is classified and managed	• How should HR systems adapt to AI-augmentable vs. AI-substitutable skills? • What configurations best support hybrid human–AI roles?	Extends the value–uniqueness framework to include AI complementarity; shifts analysis from jobs to tasks/skills
Human capital emergence (Ployhart and Moliterno 2011)	AI alters the behavioral, cognitive, and affective conditions for emergence	• How does AI-mediated collaboration affect team learning and shared cognition? • What new emergence pathways arise in human–AI–human systems?	Reframes emergence as sociotechnical; introduces AI as both enabler and disruptor of collective capability formation
Value appropriation (Coff 1997, 1999)	AI tools shift bargaining power and attribution dynamics	• How do personal AI tools affect employee mobility and value capture? • When do enterprise AI systems function as isolating mechanisms?	Introduces the "AI-specific Matthew Effect"; reconceptualizes value capture as shaped by tool access and attribution opacity
AI–human complementarity framework (this paper)	A multilevel model integrating configuration, emergence, and appropriation	• How do AI-augmentable skills influence career outcomes? • What governance structures ensure equitable value distribution?	Offers an integrative framework for theorizing AI's role across the human capital value chain

decomposition process to evaluate the AI-substitutability and AI-augmentability of various work components. By drawing on the HR architecture perspective (Lepak and Snell 1999), firms can reclassify not only employees or jobs but specific skills based on their strategic value, uniqueness, and AI complementarity. This skill-level classification can then inform differentiated HR strategies—ranging from automation, augmentation, or targeted development. Recent innovations such as Microsoft's People Skills agent (Mighell 2025) demonstrate the feasibility of using AI itself to support this reconfiguration process. In doing so, firms will lay the groundwork for transitioning from job-based to skill- and capability-based HR systems that are more adaptive to AI-infused work environments.

Beyond redesigning job structures, organizations should actively explore how various generative AI tools—ranging from text-based assistants to code generation and creative ideation platforms—reshape how work is performed. These tools influence how employees apply their skills, coordinate with others, and interact within increasingly hybrid human–AI–human workflows. Although academic research is only beginning to uncover the dynamics of these new interaction patterns, practitioners can lead by experimenting with different forms of human–AI teaming to better understand how AI tools support the transformation and amplification of human capital at the unit level. Firms should document, evaluate, and share best practices across units to identify scalable collaboration models, which can in turn inform theory and evidence-based HR design.

If organizations succeed in identifying AI-compatible tasks and enabling high-impact collaboration, they will be better positioned to understand how employees, AI tools, and organizational resources jointly create value. This calls for new models of value accounting and distribution that recognize the co-creative nature of performance in AI-augmented settings. Firms should develop frameworks for attributing value among key stakeholders—employees, technological infrastructure, and collaborative ecosystems. Special attention should be paid to whether star employees disproportionately benefit from this transformation due to attribution biases or performance visibility, potentially leading to inequities in recognition, compensation, and opportunity. Practitioners must remain vigilant to emerging patterns of perceived or actual unfairness and consider mechanisms for transparency, redistribution, and inclusion to ensure AI adoption does not unintentionally reinforce inequality.

Finally, in the absence of comprehensive regulatory frameworks governing generative AI in the workplace, organizations must take a proactive role in governance. This involves issuing clear internal guidelines on appropriate AI use across work contexts, aligning usage with organizational goals, and ensuring ethical, secure, and unbiased application. HR should lead efforts to ensure transparency around AI assistance, guard against algorithmic bias, and prevent unsustainable performance expectations linked to AI-enhanced output (Charlwood and Guenole 2022). Organizations must also develop policies distinguishing personal from enterprise AI tools to address data privacy, intellectual property, and

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the boundaries between personal and firm-specific knowledge. Transparent communication about how AI-supported work is evaluated and attributed is critical, as is establishing participatory governance structures that involve employees in shaping AI policies. In doing so, firms can build trust, enhance accountability, and mitigate risks. Those who lead responsibly will not only shape internal practices but also influence broader norms for ethical and sustainable AI integration in human capital systems.

8 | Conclusion

The integration of generative AI into knowledge work represents a profound shift in how employee performance is created, evaluated, and rewarded. Although AI offers the potential to enhance productivity across the workforce, its effects are unlikely to be evenly distributed. This paper challenges the assumption that AI will serve as a great equalizer, proposing instead that it may amplify existing disparities—particularly benefiting star employees who possess the domain expertise and strategic insight to extract disproportionate value from AI tools. Beyond performance, AI is also transforming the dynamics of value creation and capture between employees and firms. Personal AI tools enhance employee bargaining power by enabling portable, high-value outputs, whereas enterprise AI systems embed knowledge in proprietary infrastructure, reinforcing firm control. These developments necessitate a rethinking of foundational theories in strategic human capital.

For HR scholars and practitioners, this transformation presents both challenges and opportunities. The challenge lies in adapting to a landscape where traditional models of performance, skill valuation, and value capture may no longer apply. The opportunity lies in shaping this transformation—by designing HR systems that recognize AI-augmentable skills, fostering equitable attribution practices, and developing governance frameworks that balance innovation with fairness and transparency.

Ultimately, this paper lays the groundwork for a new era of strategic human capital theory—one that treats AI not merely as a tool, but as a co-evolving partner in the creation and distribution of value. As organizations and scholars grapple with the implications of this shift, the ability to harness AI's potential while safeguarding human dignity, equity, and agency will define the next frontier of work.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data sharing not applicable to this article as no datasets were generated or analyzed during the current study.

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